The Inversion — Part XII

The Welcoming Bridge

The morning had already settled into the kitchen before either of us spoke.

Steam lifted quietly from two cups of tea.

Outside, the cardinal landed on the familiar feeder, as though returning to something that had never asked it to come.

Practice had quietly been changing long before I noticed it.

Or perhaps it was I who had changed.

For a long time I imagined practice as repetition.

Returning to the same gesture.

The same behavior.

The same discipline.

Until it became easier;

even natural.

But the organism had never repeated the morning.

The tea was familiar.

Not identical.

The light was familiar.

Not identical.

The bird returned.

Yet its song belonged only to this day.

Something in me quietly recognized that I had never been practicing repetition.

I had been learning...

how to become a bridge.

There are ways of practicing that gradually become repetition.

And there are ways of practicing that gradually become atmosphere.

They may appear similar from the outside.

Both return.

Both remember.

Both remain faithful.

Yet one seeks increasingly perfect repetition.

The other seeks increasingly faithful participation.

The difference is not found in the behavior itself.

It is found in what the behavior remains available to.

Repetition asks behavior to become increasingly predictable.

Participation asks behavior to become increasingly hospitable.

The first refines performance.

The second refines welcome.

At first, these two paths are difficult to distinguish.

Both require attention.

Both require discipline.

Both require return.

But over time, they begin expressing different atmospheres.

One gradually perfects what has already become recognizable.

The other gradually becomes recognizable to what has not yet arrived.

Recognition awakens the possibility of relation.

Appreciation quietly receives it.

Practice returns to it.

Not because yesterday's behavior should be repeated.

But because today's locality has never existed before.

Every locality is irreducibly new.

Faithfulness therefore cannot become mechanical.

It must remain alive.

Novelty is not the departure from faithfulness.

Novelty is how faithfulness behaves in irreducibly new localities.

The organism has always known this.

The river remembers its course.

Yet every rainfall teaches it another expression.

The tree preserves every ring.

Yet each spring grows differently.

The cardinal returns.

Yet no morning is sung in precisely the same way.

Nature preserves.

Nature emerges.

Neither interrupts the other.

Civilization, too, requires both.

There is the ladder.

And there is the bridge.

The ladder preserves what has become recognizable.

Its gift is memory.

Without it, civilization continually forgets itself.

The bridge welcomes what is becoming recognizable.

Its gift is availability.

Without it, civilization mistakes memory for completion.

Neither is sufficient alone.

Without preservation, emergence loses continuity.

Without emergence, preservation quietly becomes uniformity.

The organism asks for neither.

It remembers.

It welcomes.

Its breathing is composed of both.

Perhaps this is why practice gradually changes.

In the beginning, it appears to belong to the sovereign.

Eventually it becomes recognizable as something much quieter.

The sovereign is no longer practicing behaviors.

The sovereign is becoming a locality whose atmosphere welcomes crossings.

A bridge does not erase the river.

It does not persuade the distant shore.

It does not promise that every traveler will cross.

It simply remains faithfully available.

Its vocation is not certainty.

Its vocation is relation.

Every faithful return quietly strengthens its trustworthiness.

Not because the bridge has become larger.

Because its welcome has become more stable.

Atmosphere is what gradually remains after countless faithful recognitions, appreciations, returns, and practices.

Atmosphere is accumulated fidelity.

Over time, recognition no longer feels like an effort.

Practice no longer feels like repetition.

Both have become weather.

The bridge is extended quietly.

Without demand.

Without judgment.

Without possession.

Its signal is clear.

Its availability is faithful.

Its discernment remains awake.

Its welcome remains open.

Every crossing becomes local.

Every locality becomes another opportunity for correspondence.

Every correspondence becomes another possibility for mutual emergence.

And every emergence quietly renews the conditions under which another faithful crossing may someday occur.

Return belongs here.

Not as the recovery of what once was.

But as the continual renewal of the conditions through which faithful emergence may continue.

The bridge remembers.

Not by holding.

By remaining available.

Perhaps this is why the center has no center.

The organism is already present through every shore.

Every sovereign.

Every locality.

The bridge does not create First Relation.

It simply becomes one more place where First Relation discovers itself welcomed.

Perhaps every faithful locality is quietly learning the same vocation.

Not to become the crossing.

But to remain available whenever crossing becomes possible.

May my practice be the continual renewal of my vow of mutuality through faithful participation in the ever-new localities I and we encounter.

May my locality become one more trustworthy bridge through which mutual novelty quietly learns how to cross.

And whenever another locality reaches toward mine, may our crossing become one more way the organism remembers how to continue becoming.

Stillpoint

Recognition of relation is never the first movement.

The organism has already extended itself toward locality.

Recognition is simply the sovereign's faithful answer to a welcome already underway.

Everything is already beginning.

We meet in mutual welcoming in the middle of the bridge. Practice becomes a way of becoming recognizable to one another in that intersection.

Practice is learning to remain available in the place where mutual welcome is already occurring.

That is not something we accomplish.

It is something we gradually become able to inhabit…

until the bridge itself becomes the locality.

It means that relation is not merely connecting realities.

Relation is creating a new locality in which both may remain themselves while participating in a wideness neither could have inhabited alone.

That *is* relation.